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Volume XXXIV Number 9; For the week  
Feb 24-Mar 2, 2009, released on Feb 23

• Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001; Phones: 23315801-4; Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi  
• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301; Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); 095120 2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080; e-mail: [arecare@indiatoday.com](mailto:arecare@indiatoday.com); Mumbai: 022-24444423-6; Fax: 24444358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Competent House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor, Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, 2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28475526-41; Telex: 041-6177  
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## From the editor-in-chief

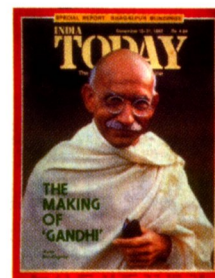
The film *Slumdog Millionaire* which is about a kid from the slums of Mumbai who wins a quiz show to earn fame and fortune, has become an international phenomenon. No film with an Indian theme has so far managed to touch so many millions of moviegoers across the world. For a film which almost never got made for the big screen and with no internationally recognisable face or bankable star, the reaction has been astonishing. Made on a \$15-million budget, it has already racked up box office earnings of \$138 million. Although set in Mumbai's slums, it is a rave across America where it has grossed \$88 million. Critics, juries and Hollywood's biggest movie stars have joined the celebration. It has won top prizes at the BAFTA, Golden Globes and Screen Actors Guild. It's given Hollywood A-list status to everyone involved—director Danny Boyle, Anil Kapoor, the unknown stars, Freida Pinto and Dev Patel—and has cemented A.R. Rahman's status as a musical genius.

What is it about *Slumdog Millionaire* that makes it so special and has earned it no less than 10 Oscar nominations? It actually had everything going against it: It's a film by a maverick British director whose career was going nowhere, adapted by scriptwriter Simon Beaufoy from a book by an Indian diplomat and made with a crew that was completely Indian, from casting director Loveleen Tandan to steadicam operator Suneil Khandpur, a largely unknown cast with a dialogue partly in Hindi and a backdrop of poverty and filth. Yet, it works.

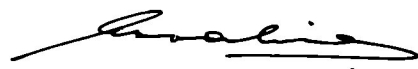
Frankly, after watching the movie, I couldn't help feeling that this was shameless pandering to western stereotypes of India but it is undoubtedly an extremely well-made film with a gripping story that lifts it to a rarefied level, an artful mixture of art and heart, grime and grit, despair and hope. Even Boyle admitted to INDIA TODAY: "What's happened is beyond rational explanation." It's something his entire cast shares. "It's karma," says Kapoor, scrolling down his emails from Ryan Seacrest, who wants to interview him, to Will Smith, who wants to shoot his next film, *Extreme Cities*, in India.

*Slumdog Millionaire* is bound to win many cinematic awards which itself will be cinematic history for an Indian-themed movie. Only two Oscars in history have an Indian connection: Satyajit Ray got a lifetime achievement award while Bhanu Athaiya won Best Costume for *Gandhi*. Our cover story sets out to analyse the phenomenon that the movie has become. Executive Editor Kaveree Bamzai spoke to all the people involved in the movie, and we tracked down the two slum kids whose lives have also changed so radically. We also conducted an eight-city poll to find out the reaction of Indian audiences to the film and whether the controversy around its stark depiction of poverty and slums was justified. Most thought it was a good film and were not so bothered about how India had been portrayed in the film.

I'm sure *Slumdog Millionaire* will set off a slew of films which will be centred around India and Indian life. Regardless of the awards, the audience has made it a hit film and it deserves every accolade it gets.



OUR DECEMBER 1980  
COVER ON GANDHI

  
(Aroon Purie)